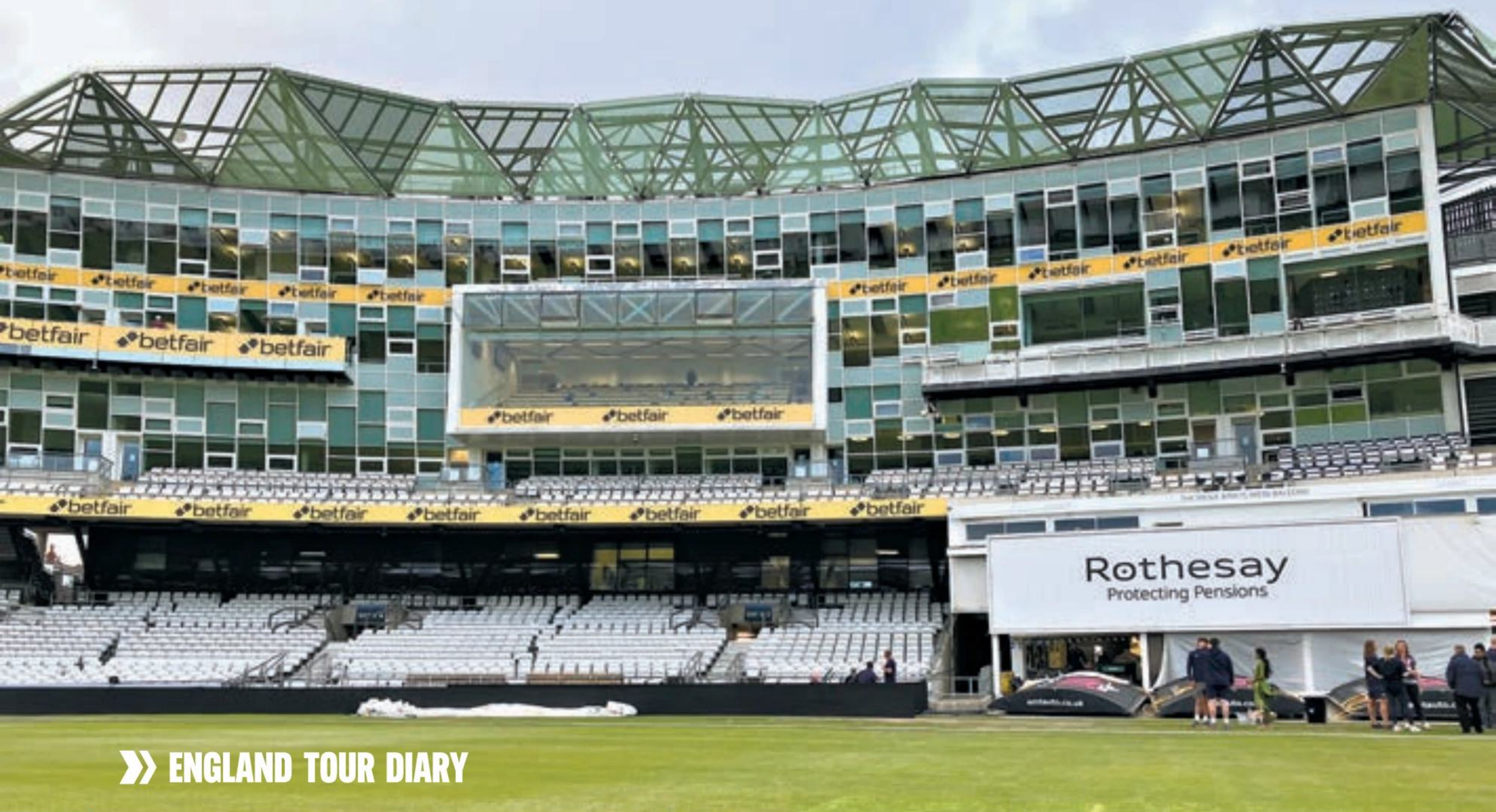




» ENGLAND TOUR DIARY

Media hub: The main pavilion at Headingley Stadium in Leeds, with the media box (the rectangular structure at the centre), as seen from the pitch. N. SUDARSHAN

Hidden grounds, lukewarm meals, and the heat that won

A Test without stars, food without soul, and summer without mercy. The Diary begins its English tour with a **rude wake-up call.**

N. Sudarshan

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The Yorkshire Cricket Ground at Headingley, Leeds, is deceptive at best. It is hardly visible from a distance, surrounded as it is by smallish hills, but not really in a valley to be so well hidden. The sight of the not-so-high floodlights as one approaches the gates is a giveaway, but it doesn't truly dawn until one enters the ground that there is an 18,000-seater in there.

On the eve of the first Test between England and India, this veil and haze extended to the cricketing atmosphere too. Most cab drivers in Leeds are of Asian origin, with a majority from the cricket-mad countries of India and Pakistan. Yet, hardly anyone knew there was a match scheduled. One Mansoor knew of Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma but bluntly told the Diary that it was wasting time covering a series without the two stalwarts.

The Diary is often told in familial circles how elite sport is a wasted

exercise. But this was a rude shock. The stadium, however, was packed with fans all through the tie, and most of them were English. By the fifth day, they all went home a happy lot, for England pulled off a stunning five-wicket win. Perhaps the Asians knew there wouldn't be a happy ending — and that's why they feigned ignorance?

Of plain rice and crushed expectations

The Diary loves food, especially good vegetarian fare. It has been spoilt by years of good catering